

on most social networking sites, it's clearly much less desirable than, say, a site that's meant purely for business partnerships. It's this wish to separate work from fun that has made sites such as LinkedIn and Ryze such successes. Apart from just finding people in your line of work and making business contacts, business networking sites let you make contacts from across all industry verticals, and expose you to much more than your normally closed little world. Also, it's great to get to know alternative ways of functioning, personally and on a company level, and learn of interesting strategies and ideas. We'll look closely at business networking later.

Although dating, friends, and business takes care of the majority of online networking, there are still thousands of sites that offer none of these primarily. Forums, for example, are primarily used to exchange information, waste time, share news, express opinions, and more. Then there are sites such as Wikipedia and Yahoo! Answers, which depend solely on the people who use the site, so they are very social and community-driven.

1.3 Etiquette And Security

Social networking is very much like real life in the sense that you're still dealing with real people. All the etiquette you enforce upon yourself in real life when dealing with friends or colleagues should be put into use when networking online as well.

There are no fixed rules; we cannot write out a rulebook for you. But in general, sites such as MySpace, Freindster, Facebook, and Orkut can be considered a little more relaxed than, say, Ryze and LinkedIn. So although you can go about joking with your buddies in Orkut, doing the same on LinkedIn will lose you some business.

For the more informal sites, here's a little set of rules to follow:

1. Choose a good nickname (if you'd rather not use your real name) and try not to choose one that sounds retarded.